

A BURGEONING ARENA

Esports has finally taken hold of many Indian gamers. A FICCI-EY report sheds light on the current state of the Esport universe

- No. of Esports players across all competitive levels: **1 million in 2022** from 600,000 in 2021. Expected to reach 2.5 million in 2023
- No. of Esports teams: **110,000 in 2022**, from 100,000 in 2021 , a growth of 10 per cent. Can reach 125,000 in 2023
- Prize money for Esports tournaments: **Rs 15 crore in 2022**, lower than the Rs 22 crore in 2021. Estimated to rise to Rs 30 crore in 2023
- Airtime of competitive level games: **4,500 broadcast hours in 2022**, a jump of almost 50 per cent from 3,100 hours in 2021. Expected to rise to 6,000 hours in 2023
- Broadcasting platforms for Esports: **14 in 2022**
- No. of brands investing in Esports: **80 in 2022**, from 72 in 2021. Could touch 100 in 2023
- No. of female players: **22 per cent** in 2022, from 18 per cent in 2021. Estimated to reach 28 per cent in 2023

Darshan Bata, captain of the Hangzhou-bound Dota 2 team, disagrees. "I compare [Dota and LoL] to chess, as you are strategising about next moves," says the 29-year-old. "Every game is different. There are over 120 characters to pick from; each character has different spells and powers that you have to memorise." In Esports, he says, mental strength and fortitude take precedence over physical ability. To naysayers, Bata says, "If they try the game once, they will know it's not that easy. You need to grind a lot."

As PC (personal computer) gamers, Shenoy and Bata are in the minority among the online gaming community in India. With its low data costs, India is a mobile-first gaming market, which accounts for 85 per cent of the total revenue. Affordable smartphones and high internet penetration have amplified opportunities for gamers to make a living through Esports and content creation, says gamer Animesh Agarwal, a.k.a. 8Bit Thug, co-founder of S8UL Esports and founder & CEO of 8Bit Creatives, which represents gamers like Mortal. Gaming PCs and laptops, on the other hand, are priced from Rs 1 lakh onwards and consoles cost around Rs 50,000. "Sponsors look for viewership and MOBA games are not popular in India," says Bata. "To understand a game [like Dota], you need to play it for a long period of time." Fewer tournaments mean fewer players, making MOBA gamers a niche community.

Regardless, the Esports Federation of India (ESFI) is ensuring India's Asian Games contingent is well-prepared—Bata and his four Dota 2 teammates have a coach-cum-psychologist-cum-analyst too. After all, Dota was the game that brought India a historic bronze medal at the inaugural Commonwealth Esports Championships in Birmingham last year. Furthermore, the ESFI has partnered with computer accessories distributor Hama to provide athletes with mouses and keyboards. Bata sets aside four to six hours daily to prepare, but only after work—as a stock market trader. "Mobile gamers have made it in India, but PC gaming still has a long way to go," he says.

> THE INDIAN ESPORT SCENARIO NEEDS INVESTMENT FROM PUBLISHERS AND BRANDS SO THAT MORE TOURNAMENTS ARE ORGANISED

The Asian Games could help bridge that gap, hopes Ayan Biswas, a Street Fighter V gamer from Birnagar, West Bengal. In a tier-III city like Birnagar, Biswas is an anomaly as a professional gamer, but playing for the country gives him credibility. "From being told 'what will you accomplish with gaming?' to 'Why aren't you playing games, you have to go to the Asian Games', the transition is amazing," says Biswas with a laugh. He is also excited at the prospect of travelling abroad for the first time courtesy the Games. "There is still not much awareness about Esports. I hope it changes when people see it broadcast live at the Asian Games," adds the 24-year-old, who works with the postal department. "If I do well, I can look at getting sponsorship."

Twenty-year-old Charanjot Singh from Chandigarh is India's top FIFA—a football simulation video game—athlete and one of its two representatives at the Games. Unlike Biswas, the BA student of the city's SD College has competed in four international tournaments in 2023—in London, Riyadh, Malaysia and South Korea.

Indian gamers became eligible to play in FIFA global series tournaments from 2021. Singh is a precocious talent. At age 15, he won his first tournament—the FIFA Ultimate Championship—the first he played. Incredibly, he didn't own a gaming console at the time. Since acquiring a PlayStation 4 and later 5, Singh hasn't looked